relations harder and created serious problems for the US-Pakistan relationship—especially when Americans were dying at the hands of Chinese-supported insurgents in Vietnam.[56]

After Gandhi's trip, Rusk felt any resulting euphoria in India needed to be tempered.[57] Otherwise, Delhi might regress in terms of reforms and reconciliation. Thus the US continued to stress that it wanted India to decrease defense expenditures, including from the Soviet Union. To ensure that Indian policymakers translated their promises into performance, Johnson also wanted aid to be doled out in tranches.[58]

However, Indian officials felt this approach was counterproductive to Johnson's objective since it weakened Gandhi's hand. Rusk had earlier himself warned about the adverse impact the lack of food aid would have on Gandhi's political position. In an election year, it would render her unable to make the kind of economic reforms that the US wanted.[59] In May, Bowles reported that support for the US and the Indian government had initially increased after Gandhi's visit. Since then, however, there had been Soviet-sponsored and leftist attacks on Gandhi's government that highlighted US "strings" and ambitions in India. The ambassador noted that the prime minister was defending the US-India relationship, but to sustain her position and policy, Washington had to be subtler about pressure and deliver on promises.[60]

The Downside of Dependence

If India had not continued to need the US for internal strengthening and external protection, Gandhi might have sought to disengage from the US to relieve the domestic pressure and acquire some international maneuverability. She was realistic, however, about the necessity of the relationship because of the country's weaknesses. She might not have liked the constraints that came with that dependence—and publicly insisted that India could "do without" aid—but recognized the necessity of dependence. As Surjit Mansingh has noted, the view in the prime minister's secretariat was that "India's national interest demanded as much support as possible from both superpowers." In that context, "the West could not be ignored." The US was the only option for the kind of food aid that India needed. Furthermore, the Soviet Union had not shown the willingness or ability to aid India economically to the same extent.[61] Finally, as Indian foreign